at the Toronto immigration law firm Green and Spiegel, notes, "Australia is seen as more isolated. And the US is less attractive given the racial tensions and the reality that it's very difficult to obtain a green card down the road. In Canada, a lot of the agents are really promising permanent residence, though it's not quite that easy."

Six years ago, China was the top source country for international students in Canada, sending twice as many students as India. By 2017, India had caught up, and after a brief dip due to Covid-19, bagged well over a third of the 397,210 study permits issued last year (*see box*).

This surge has drawn to India companies like ApplyBoard, a platform connecting students and recruitment partners to global educational institutions. The Canadian company opened a new office in Gurugram in October, and a third of its 1,500-strong workforce is in India. Co-founder and CEO Martin Basiri says, "I think we'll become 20-30 times bigger in India."

In fact, Indian families have been more or less funding higher education in many parts of Canada over the past few years. In Ontario, Canada's most populous province, public colleges now earn Canadian $1.7 billion, or 68 per cent of their tuition revenue, from international students, of which nearly two-thirds are from India. According to the latest figures by the Canadian government, international students contributed over Canadian $22 billion to the nation's economy in 2018.

Nearly two-thirds of Indian students in Canada choose courses related to business, science and computing, and nearly three-quarters choose the job market-oriented colleges over universities. The US is home to far more top-ranked universities than Canada, but it's common knowledge that many students view the education credential more as a pathway to eventual immigration.

Canada's Post-Graduate Work Permit (PGWP) programme is more liberal than the Optional Practical Training (OPT), its American counterpart. While the OPT gives graduates 12 months—and an extra two years to STEM (science, technology, engineering and mathematics) graduates—to stay on in the US and find a job (but only in their field of study), the PGWP holder can stay in Canada for up to three years and work with any employer.

Canada has also been steadily increasing its immigration targets, hoping to welcome over 410,000 immigrants next year. Students graduating from Canadian institutions and having Canadian work experience will be part of this cohort, making a Canadian education even more attractive to aspiring immigrants. On the other hand, the H1B work visa in the US is subject to periodic political pressures, and the wait for a green card, especially for Indian-born applicants, can often take a decade or more.

On the cost front, while international students pay 4-5 times higher tuition than domestic students in Canada, it's still about a third cheaper than the US. Kaur, for instance, paid over Canadian $32,000 (nearly Rs 19 lakh) for her four-semester course at Fleming College, Peterborough, Ontario.

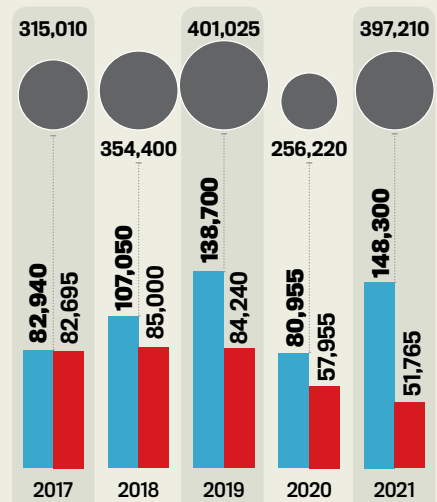
However, the jump in the numbers of Indian students in Canada is also starting to ring alarm bells in some quarters. For Gurpreet S. Malhotra, CEO of Indus Community Services, the problems are glaring. "Landlords have up to 20 young people in a three-bedroom home," he says. "In order to survive, students are often working under the table for less than minimum wage. We have seen increase in Indian student suicides...as well as criminal activities taking advantage of these young people for transporting drugs and human trafficking. And it all starts with consultants in India paid to do this marketing to bring people over." Jain adds that "it's the responsibility of the federal government to regulate agents and consultants, and they're not regulating them properly". Anupma Cvejic, co-founder of Sunoh, another community group, has been conducting webinars for students in India, detailing the challenges they can expect to face in Canada.

Sheridan College, a public college in Brampton, near Toronto, has long been a popular destination for students from India. However, concerned about the limited social infrastructure that was available to support these students, it started slowing its international student intake three years ago, at a time when many Ontario colleges were ramping up recruitment, especially from India.

Study permits issued in 2021 show that it has been another record-setting year for Indian students heading to Canada. According to their well-wishers, however, the students' real education needs to start before they embark on their journey to a land over 11,000 kilometres away. ■

A GROWING INDIAN PRESENCE

Study permits granted by Canada



Country of origin India China Total

(Source: Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada)